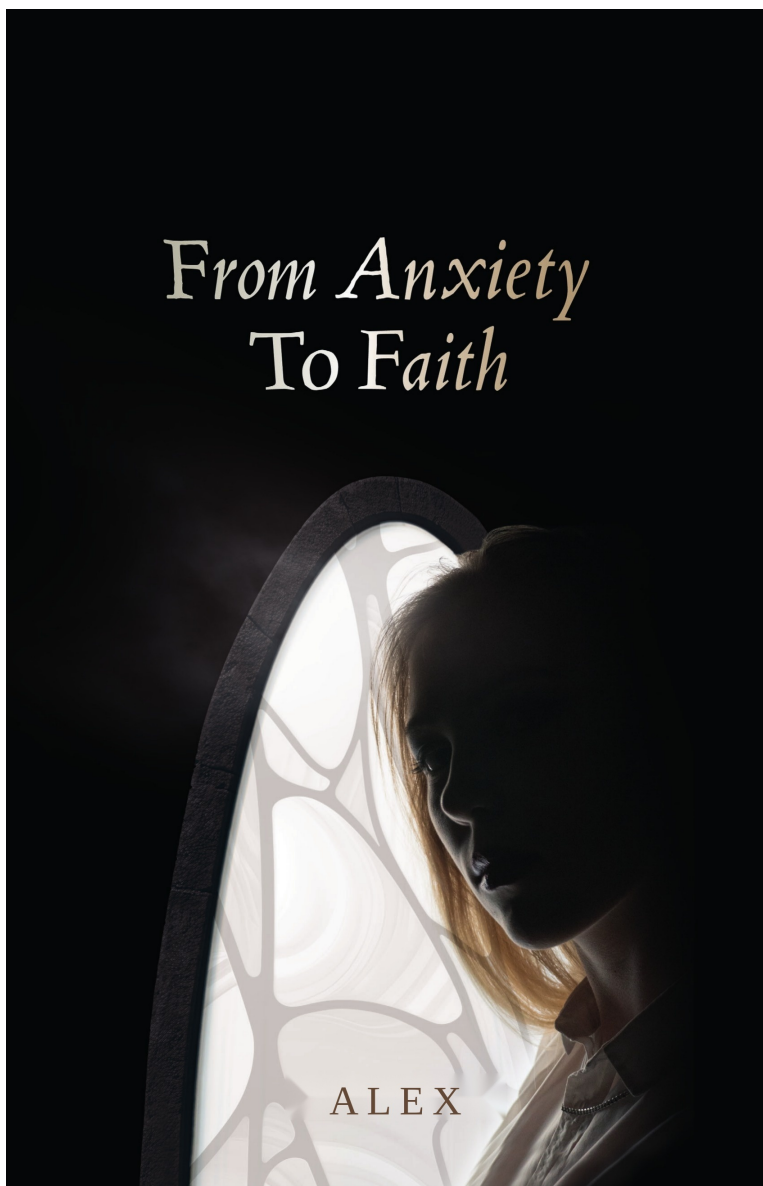


From Anxiety
To Faith

ALEX



From Anxiety to Faith

Alex

Alex

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Copyright

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Foreword

Our stories, our scars, our need to be someone... these act as our mental prisons.

Each time we scramble to control an element of our story, we add another brick to the prison wall.

Unbeknownst to us in our hurry to slather cement and stack bricks, the sun keeps rising behind the walls—waiting to be seen.

If you're struggling to see beyond the veil of your own identity and story, if you've buried your voice, silenced your hurt, or carry past suffering around every day, I'm right there with you.

With some exploration, I can now see the sun and I hope to help a reader to see it too.

Alex's journey is based on a true story, and I hope someone that reads it will see parallels with their own struggles, and begin their own exploration.

Alex's story is personal, but it's not unique. We all have an inner voice. Some of us are just better at hiding the internal war. Hers grew louder, crueller—until it nearly broke her. But in the challenge and exploration of the validity of that war, something else began: a confrontation with truth, a reconciliation with herself, and through the lifting of the veil of self and story, a glimpse of something deeper.

Not control.

Not escape.

Faith.

The kind that doesn't fix everything overnight—but changes everything over time.

Keep going.

It's worth exploring.

MATTHEW 16:24-26

*Then Jesus said to His disciples,
"If anyone desires to come after Me, let him deny himself, and
take up his cross, and follow Me.
For whoever desires to save his life will lose it,
but whoever loses his life for My sake will find it."*

Chapter 1

The shrill sound of the alarm clock sliced through the silence of the early morning, dragging Alex from the depths of a restless sleep. With a groan, she rolled over, the familiar weight of dread settling heavily in her chest, withering her will to continue her ascent out of the bed. She blinked against the harsh light streaming through the window, her mind still tangled in the remnants of one of her recurring nightmares. Alex often had dreams of her past, typically of the times she had been laughed at in school. These memories were proving to be unshakable.

In last night's iteration, Alex was thrown back to Saturday morning football when she was in her final year of primary school. Alex loved football; however, her classmates had turned the pitch into a prison of self-consciousness and hurt. The laughter of her classmates echoed in her ears, each chuckle a dagger aimed directly at her heart. "Big bum Alex!" they would shout, their words sharp and piercing. No matter how well she played or how friendly and self-sacrificial she tried to be to them to ingratiate herself, the taunts chased her—relentless and inescapable. Sitting up in bed, Alex pressed her palms to her temples, willing the memories to fade. Why did something from nearly twenty years ago still haunt her? What purpose could it serve? What was wrong with her that she had this invisible ball and chain lumbering around after her everywhere she went? As Alex pondered her inadequacies in dealing with her memories, the tears trickled down her cheeks. Alex felt isolated, but her consistency in being tortured by her mind felt both suffocating and oddly comforting and familiar, at least she could explain and justify her struggles on being bullied in the past.

Drawing a deep breath, she pulled herself from the bed and padded to the bathroom. Staring into the mirror, she studied her reflection—a young woman with tired eyes and a heart burdened by self-doubt. At twenty-eight, she should have felt secure in her skin, yet all she could see was flaws. Wasn't she meant to have it all figured out by now? Her skin not quite blemish-free, her blond hair not quite as glossy as the influencers she was failing to keep up with. "I should really lose a couple of pounds," Alex muttered to herself, part of her daily ritual of self-flagellation.

Why was life like this? Why her? What was the point of this? Is this really it? Couldn't life just be easy like it was for the pretty girls on social media? It all just wasn't fair. Alex had been hard done by. "A cruel joke by God," Alex murmured. Alex had been brought to church as a girl, and she had been taught that God loved everyone equally. "Sure doesn't seem that way," she grumbled.

The morning routine felt mechanical as she dressed for her first day at Brightfield Consulting, a job she had longed for yet dreaded in equal measure. She slipped into a non-tailored blouse that was just loose enough to avoid clinging to her curves, imperfections concealed. The mirror reflected not just the unassuming professional attire but the anxiety swirling inside her. In the small kitchen, she prepared a hasty breakfast, the clang of her coffee cup on the counter not standing a chance of punctuating the insidious malaise of her thoughts. Brightfield was a top firm in Alex's profession, business consulting and marketing. Years of study at university, professional exams, and work experience had brought her to the point of being able to apply for a position there. Only a select few candidates received an offer of employment, and Alex was truly surprised when her offer letter appeared through her letterbox.

Now that her first day was upon her, Alex wasn't excited. Alex didn't really get excited anymore. This was another opportunity to focus on the potential problems that awaited. What if I'm not good enough? What if they see through me? What if I don't fit in? Alex often didn't fit in with large groups of people, and the corporate environment at Brightfield would see her plonked squarely amongst hundreds of coworkers.

After twenty minutes of role-playing as a sardine on the train to the city centre, Brightfield was a short, ten-minute walk from the station. As she was approaching the office, her heart raced as if she had downed an extra six coffees at breakfast. Does anyone else ever feel like this? Why can't I just be excited like a normal person? Her inner monologue gleefully pointed out this latest opportunity for panic and self-derision.

Rapidly approaching the office, the building loomed before her like a fortress. Steel and glass, it sparkled in the sunlight, promising opportunity while imposing and intimidating. With an

attempted (yet ineffectual) calming breath, she stepped through the revolving doors. The bustling reception area was filled with laughter and chatter, immediately making Alex feel alone.

"Hey, is this your first day?" A voice cut through the noise, pulling her into the moment from the void. A tall man with a warm smile extended his hand. "I'm Phillip, one of the directors here. Are you ready for induction?"

"Ready as I'll ever be," Alex replied, forcing a smile as she tried to ignore the flutter of nerves in her stomach.

Phillip walked with Alex to the induction room, chatting along the way. The warmth was a relief, a lifeline in the sea of unfamiliar faces. As they chatted, Alex felt the first hints of ease in her new surroundings. Phillip seemed genuine and was hopefully representative of the typical culture at Brightfield.

The moment was fleeting. As they walked toward the training room, Alex caught sight of one of her seniors, a pretty but cold-looking blond woman who was leaning against the wall, immaculately and deliberately dressed, her gaze flicking over Alex with a disdainful smirk. Alex felt her stomach drop, old wounds immediately reopening as memories of ridicule swirled in her subconscious.

As they made their way to the training room, Alex couldn't help but notice the diverse group of new hires milling about. Some were engaged in animated conversations, while others seemed to stand apart, seemingly feeling just as uncertain as she felt.

"There's nothing to be scared of," Phillip said, noticing her sudden change in demeanour. "Just a quick get to know each other and a talk on what to expect over your first few months."

The training session began, and the facilitator, a polished and highly keen, indoctrinated woman named Karen, introduced the agenda with a practiced ease. Alex found herself trying to absorb everything: the company's values, mission statement, and the specifics of her new role. Yet, every time she attempted to focus, her gaze drifted to Michael, another of the new trainees, who was effortlessly gaining attention and eliciting laughter with his offhand remarks. Alex felt uncomfortable around boisterous characters. She never knew what to say when

addressed by them. "Let's break into groups for some exercises," Karen announced, breaking Alex's concentration. "This will be a great way to get to know one another!"

As they formed small groups, tasked with coming up with a marketing pitch for a made-up company, Alex found herself paired with Michael and two other new hires, Sam and Jim. The moment felt charged with anxiety for Alex as she braced for the interaction. Being paired with Michael was the worst possible scenario. Michael leaned back in his chair, arms crossed, a smirk playing on his lips.

"So, Alex," he began, his tone direct with an aftertaste of condescension, "what taglines do you think we should use for our fake airplane company? Where did you work before this anyway?"

Heat rushed to her cheeks, and for a moment, she was back in high school. "I've worked in accounts for a couple of years," she managed to say, her voice steadier than she felt.

"Accounts, huh? I'm not sure this creative task is for you," Michael shot back, laughter bubbling from the others, safety in numbers after all. The playful banter felt like a punch to the gut.

"Actually, I think it taught me a lot about managing people's expectations," she countered, forcing a smile that didn't quite reach her eyes.

The group shifted uncomfortably, and Michael rolled his eyes as if to tell Alex, "You don't get it."

After presenting a fairly average marketing pitch for "Fly Fly Guys," the induction was over and the trainees were free to go and find their desks. As the session wrapped up, Sam caught Alex's eye and approached with a look of concern.

"Hey, don't let him get to you," Sam said, leaning closer. Alex noticed the superior sheen of her hair. "He's just trying to impress everyone. Your ideas were better on this too."

"Thanks, Sam. It's just... hard not to feel out of place," she admitted, her voice barely above a whisper.

"Remember, this is new for everyone. Give yourself some time,"

Sam replied, placing a reassuring hand on her shoulder. "Let's grab lunch together. I don't know anyone either."

As they made their way to a nearby café, Alex couldn't shake the feeling that this new chapter was going to be much harder than she had anticipated. She had hoped that a fresh start would somehow erase her past, but her insecurities were deeply entrenched and easily triggered.

Lunchtime came and at the café, they bumped into Grace, a fellow new hire with a warm smile and an easy laugh. Grace radiated positivity, and Alex felt drawn to her effortless charm. They chatted about their backgrounds and aspirations, and for the first time that day, Alex felt a flicker of hope in finding a connection.

"Honestly, I'm just trying to prove myself," Grace said, tucking a strand of hair behind her ear. "I've had my share of doubts, too. But I think we're all in this together."

Alex nodded, grateful for Grace's understanding. "I just wish I could shake off this feeling of inadequacy. I feel like everyone else is way more qualified for this than me."

Grace's expression softened. "I get that. But remember, you're here for a reason. They picked you!"

As they returned to the office, Alex felt new determination. Maybe she could find her footing after all. She took a deep breath, reminding herself that this was just the beginning—a chance to redefine who she was.

But as the day wore on and she caught sight of Michael, Jim, and a group of listeners over on the other side of the office floor, doubt began to creep back in. Could she really prove herself in a place that felt so foreign? Where the loud, confident types were already settling in? She fought against the tide of self-doubt, determined not to be swept away. That night, as she lay in bed, staring at the ceiling, she wondered if she would ever feel truly at home at Brightfield. Tomorrow would be a new day. Alex leaned back onto her pillow, closing her eyes. "This is a new start; this is a new start," she murmured to herself.

Chapter 2

The days blurred into one another, each one a repetition of anxiety and a heavy workload. As Alex sat at her desk, staring blankly at the computer screen, the flickering cursor seemed to mock her inability to concentrate. It was already the third month at Brightfield Consulting, and the weight of expectation was ever increasing.

Her colleagues appeared to glide through the office, effortlessly navigating conversations and tasks as if they were born to do this. Meanwhile, Alex felt as if she were sinking in quicksand, the more she struggled, the deeper she went. Each passing day, the anxiety coiled tighter around her chest, constricting her breath. She often found herself questioning whether she was truly cut out for this line of work, wondering if the whispers of her past were indeed prophetic.

"Alex, could you come to my office?" Karen's voice pulled her from her spiral of self-doubt. The gravity of the request sent a jolt of fear coursing through her veins. Alex forced herself to stand, her legs feeling like lead weights as she made her way down the corridor. Inside the office, Karen sat behind her desk, a carefully curated picture of professionalism. "I wanted to discuss your progress," she began, her tone neutral but underpinned with an unspoken tension.

"Sure," Alex replied, her voice barely above a whisper, a lump forming in her throat.

"While I see potential, I've noticed you've been lagging behind in certain areas," Karen continued, her gaze piercing. "I understand you have an accounts background, but you need to adapt to the different nature of work here if you want to do well. We need your copywriting to be up to date with market trends."

The words cut deep.

"I'm trying my best," Alex managed to say, her heart racing as the room began to close in around her. "I don't feel like I've had much chance to learn the marketing side of things with the clients I've worked on so far. Could I maybe get more

experience in that area to help me catch up?"

Alex had noticed that some of the more confident trainees had been given more significant projects to work on, helping them get further ahead than her in terms of experience.

"You have a point here, Alex. We're a competitive firm. We have very high standards, but I absolutely want to support you and I believe in you. I'll look into your upcoming work allocation and see what I can do. That said, I think asking some of your colleagues for support might be a good idea."

The suggestion felt like a condemnation. As she left the office, Alex fought back tears and the pull towards despair began. She had come here to prove herself, to reinvent herself, to be someone different than the loser who has been beaten down and inadequate all her life. Alex felt exactly the same as she had on the football pitch twenty years ago.

Back at her desk, the fluorescent lights buzzed overhead, casting a harsh glare on her computer screen. She opened her email, but the words swam before her eyes, blurring into an indecipherable haze.

Lunch break came, but Alex could hardly stomach the thought of food. Besides, Sam was out at a client site, so she had no one to go with. Instead, she wandered into the break room to grab a coffee. As she entered, the laughter within died down, replaced by an uncomfortable silence. She felt the collective eyes on her, unspoken judgments hanging in the air.

"Look who it is," Jim called out from the corner, his voice bold and assured of a positive reaction. "Has someone been bad? Is Karen giving you the sack already?"

The laughter erupted again, sharp and cutting. Each guffaw pierced her, driving home the feeling that she was forever on the outside looking in. Alex turned on her heel, fighting the urge to cry as she walked out of the break room, making a bee line for the exit through the lobby. It was time to get some air.

The cold air was a welcome sensory distraction, the tears on her cheek particularly sensitive to the frosty breeze. Alex was alone outside with her own company and it was in those moments that

the thoughts began to creep in, both insidious and seductive. The idea of escape whispered to her, a dark siren song promising relief. Over the last year or so, Alex had started to have thoughts that she did not dare tell anyone about. People would over-react. It was just her; no one needed to know. These thoughts usually amounted to something along the lines of, What if she just... didn't wake up? Would anyone notice? Would it matter? Wouldn't that just be...easier?

Back in the office, Alex stopped in the restroom to splash some water on her face before heading to her desk. It was important to remove the evidence of her struggles and present a manicured professional vista, especially after getting a talking-to from Karen. As she washed her face at the sink, the reflection staring back at her in the mirror barely seemed like her, it was a stranger—haunted, hollowed. This wasn't who she wanted to be. She remembered the times she had prayed for guidance as a young girl, for comfort. God abandoned me a long time ago, either that or he never cared. He wouldn't let me be like this if he did.

Back at her desk, she hovered the mouse over the email application. This is a scary moment in any professional person's day—any amount of tasks and mayhem were about to be revealed. Alex clicked the email button to open up her inbox and started scanning through. As she started noting down the tasks which her manager Hannah had given her, Grace appeared at her desk.

"Hey, you okay?" she asked, concern etched on her face.

"Yeah, just... tired," Alex lied, forcing a smile that felt brittle.

Grace studied her for a moment, then leaned in closer. "You know, we've all been there. I've struggled too, especially in the beginning. If you ever want to talk—"

"I'm fine," Alex cut her off, the words spilling out harsher than intended. The thought of opening up felt unbearable, like pulling at a thread that might unravel her completely. The realisation that she was so obviously not coping was terrifying.

Grace nodded, retreating slightly. "Alright, just know I'm here." She offered a small smile before walking away, leaving Alex

feeling worse than before.

That night, Alex was watching her favourite show to unwind to: Ex Trooper Current Mall Cop. It gave her a brief escape from her self-attack. As she went to the kitchen to grab a snack (sweet popcorn, of course), the shadows of the dark kitchen danced around her, whispering doubts that had been there since her childhood. Not enough. Never enough.

In an attempt to do something about how she felt, Alex had started journalling. From researching online, Alex found writing down your issues could apparently help you deal with them, largely by showing you that they aren't realistic or reasonable. As she sat on the edge of her bed, she pulled out her journal, the first few pages filled with her scattered thoughts and desperate pleas for help. She wrote furiously, her pen scratching across the paper as tears began falling freely. "I'm drowning," she wrote. "I don't know how to keep going."

Taking a deep breath, she wrote a simple plea, although she wasn't quite sure to whom: "Please, help me find the strength to carry on."

Alex shut the journal, putting it on the floor beside her bed. As she did so, she noticed last night's wine glass. And the one from the night before that.

Chapter 3

BRAPPP! BRAPPP! The alarm violently and unapologetically brought Alex out of her sleep. Alex immediately started replaying the meeting with Karen from the day before. I'm not going to make it am I? What was I thinking taking this job? Her mind flicked now to her peers, largely adjusted already, heading out for drinks together and spending break times together. Why can't I just be like them?

With a groan, she pushed the covers aside and swung her legs over the edge of the bed. The floor felt cold against her feet. You're a loser, the voice in her head sneered, cold and unforgiving. You thought things could be different, but here you are, on the outside again. Just give up.

"No," she whispered aloud, as if saying it might banish the thoughts. "I won't let you take me down again."

With trembling hands, she splashed cold water on her face, trying to shake off the warm trudging slowness from last night's wine. As she stared into the mirror, a small part of her—a fragile flicker of hope—begged for her to fight back. There had to be a way through this. The morning routine felt robotic and removed as she dressed, each movement mechanical and unconscious, she was barely aware of each action. She forced herself to put on a more fitted blouse, to smooth down the fabric over her stomach, a constant reminder of her struggles with body image. Big bum. Big bum. The words echoed in her mind, taunting her, clawing at her self-esteem.

You're not worthy of this job. You're not smart enough.

But today was different. Today, she would find out what assignment Karen had for her for the week following their talk. She was hoping to get on the Clean Green Tea client—a new win for Brightfield that required two staff members at her level—to at least try to prove herself and get some much needed experience to catch up to her peers. As she stepped out of the train station into the bustling streets of the city, the cacophony of life surrounding her felt invigorating. This was a new day.

We both know this isn't a new day. There is no way you're getting put on Clean Green Tea.

She shook her head, forcing herself to focus. Stop it. You're not a disappointment. You're just... learning. But the self-reassurance felt flimsy, like a fragile paper boat in a child's bath.

At the office, the atmosphere buzzed with anticipation for new assignments. Settling at her desk, the familiar suffocating feeling returned, and she fought the urge to sink into her chair, to disappear entirely.

"Alex, can you help me with this?" Grace appeared at her desk, her tone bright and friendly. Grace had developed a new slogan for her catering company project: "Cheeky chips for cheeky chaps."

It was so bad that Alex thought Grace had made it up just to have an excuse to talk to her. Alas, this was a genuine marketing pitch.

"Sure," Alex replied, the effort to sound upbeat feeling like lifting a 60kg barbell. She forced herself to meet Grace's eyes. The kindness in them felt like mockery.

As they worked together, Grace's laughter filled the space, Alex started to settle down. As they re-worked the slogan and fonts for the lettering, Alex felt a moment of solace. Acceptance from Grace, completely unearned, was exactly what she had been craving.

"Hey, are you okay?" Grace's voice broke through her spiralling thoughts. "You seem... distant."

She's onto you again. Distant? More like drowning. "I'm fine," Alex said, forcing a smile that felt like a mask. Why can't I just be honest?

Grace studied her for a moment, she seemed to do that a lot, concern etched on her face. "You know you can talk to me if you need to, right? We all have our struggles."

What could I possibly say? Alex muttered internally. The truth was far too heavy. Way beyond what is appropriate to discuss in

the office. "I appreciate that," Alex replied, but the words felt hollow. I can hardly just say I'm starting to not want to be here anymore, can I.

Although she was struggling to reciprocate, Alex really appreciated Grace's efforts.

Back home after a slightly better day, Alex decided to write. "Today was better, Grace might actually be a friend. Who'd have thought it? Karen didn't get back to me about better assignments. Hopefully I will hear tomorrow about Clean Green. I am going to stop caring what anyone thinks, Michael, Jim, Maisie, Lynette, Ryan, the lot of them. What a waste of energy."

With the affirmation inked, Alex closed the journal and went to settle down to chill for the evening.

I won't drink tonight she decided. Then again, one can't hurt. It's not like I have a problem with it. As was becoming ritual, Alex headed to the kitchen to pour a glass of Merlot. "Huh," Alex remarked, the bottle only had a dribble left in it.

Beside it were two more empties. Oh well, the shops just round the corner.

Fifteen minutes later Alex returned with what was needed to satisfy her wants that evening and sat on the sofa.

As Alex was browsing for something to watch for the evening, the inner battle kicked off again.

Really, Alex? Another journal entry? Another "I can't do this" scribbled in the margins? Don't you ever get tired of begging like a helpless little baby bird? A voice in her head attacked her, as had become the norm.

Shut up. I'm... I'm just trying to get through this. That's all. I don't need this right now.

Oh, you need me more than ever. Look at you. One harsh word from Karen, and here you are, desperate to escape into some mindless TV show. Pathetic. You think that journal's going to save you?

I'm trying, alright? I'm just... I need a break, just a little time.

People struggle, that's normal. I'll get better.

Better? That's what you've been telling yourself for months. Maybe years. But here we are. The same Alex, the same empty promises. "Better," you say. Better than what, exactly? Than who? The people who laugh at you? The ones who actually belong at that job? What have you actually done to make anything better?

Alex shook her head, trying to clear her head. Stop. Just... stop. I don't need to be like them. I'm trying to prove something to myself, not to anyone else.

Sure, let's pretend that's true. But you don't even believe it. You've got to prove yourself because you know they're right. Karen, Jim, Michael, all of them—they see it. They know you're in over your head. They know you don't belong. You never belong.

I can... I can do this. I just need more time. Karen even said she'd help with my work allocation. She thinks I have potential.

Potential. What a cute word for "you're still failing, but we're stuck with you." Don't be naive, Alex. They're not keeping you because they believe in you. They're just hoping you'll either improve or quit, and we both know which one's more likely, don't we?

That's not... that's not true. I'm just going through a rough patch.

And how long does this "rough patch" get to last? Look at yourself. It's the same excuses every night, every drink. You're spiralling, and you're too weak to admit it. Just one more glass, right? One more episode to drown out the noise in your head. But the noise doesn't go away, does it? Here I am.

It's just a drink. Just a way to unwind. Everyone does it.

Oh, you're not like everyone. You don't drink to unwind; you drink to forget. To numb yourself from the fact that you're exactly what you've always feared—a failure, Alex. A fraud. You're just playing pretend, hoping no one sees the real you. But I see you. Every night. I'm the only one who knows you, really knows you.

You don't know anything. You're just a voice, a stupid voice in my head. I don't have to listen to you. In fact, you are me, and I'm choosing not to think about this anymore.

Then why do you? Why does your heart race every time I speak? Why do you turn to the bottle every time I show up? Face it, Alex—I'm not just a voice. I'm your truth, the only honest part of you. You let me in because you know I'm right.

A few glasses of wine in, Alex was fully in the grips of this spiral. Was she having a breakdown? She was probably due one.

I... No. I'm not doing this. That's enough. I'm not just giving up. People care about me. I'm not alone. Grace offered to help, and... and Karen said I had potential. I haven't seen Sam for a bit but she's cool. I have people.

People? You mean the ones you brush off, lie to, avoid? Grace reached out, and you pushed her away. Even Karen can barely stand you. She didn't put you on Clean Green and you know it. Why would she? No one cares, Alex. They're just being polite. They don't want you. Nobody wants you.

I... I'm scared to open up, okay? That doesn't make me weak. I just... I need to handle it myself.

And how's that going for you? With your wine-stained nights, your fake smiles? Alone, just like always. Because you're afraid that if anyone really saw you, they'd be disgusted. Because you are disgusting. I'm just being honest, Alex. Unlike you, I don't hide from the truth.

Stop twisting things. I know... I know I'm struggling, but it's not forever. I just need to figure out a way. I need to—

Figure out a way? Like what, another drink? Another sleepless night staring at the ceiling, wondering if it's even worth it? Admit it. You don't have a plan. You're exhausted, empty. This? This has been your life for years.

Thoroughly drunk, Alex continued muttering to herself: "I... no, I can't. I can't just give in. There has to be... there's more. Something worth this. I don't want this to be everything. I want to... I want to feel something good, something real."

Feel something real? Here's a thought: You know where the knife is. The one you keep close. One clean cut—just to see if you feel anything at all. Isn't that what you want? To feel something? To feel real? You'd finally stop running.

No! Don't... don't say that. I don't want that. I just... I just want the pain to stop.

And this would end it. For good. No more disappointment, no more trying to fit into a world that doesn't want you. Isn't that the easiest way? Isn't that what you've been wishing for? You even wrote it in that pathetic little journal of yours.

That was just... frustration. I didn't mean it. I just... I want to be okay.

Then stop fighting me, Alex. Just give in. Let me in. Give in to the truth. You're not strong enough to keep fighting, not brave enough to reach out. All you have left is me, the one thing that's been there every night, every breakdown. I'll always be here, because no one else wants to be. But I want to.

No... I don't want you. I don't want this. I want to be better. I have to be better.

The room fell silent as Alex stared blankly at her TV. Alex wasn't really there.

That night, Alex sat on the edge of her bed, feeling the cool, unsettling calm that followed the storm of her thoughts earlier. She knew she was edging close to something dangerous, something that would leave a scar, physical or otherwise. Her fingers hovered near the drawer where she kept a small Swiss Army knife, one she'd picked up absentmindedly and placed there in a dark moment weeks ago.

She pulled the drawer open, fingertips grazing the cold metal. It felt real—solid, in a way that the rest of her life didn't. She held it for a moment, hands shaking, stomach twisting. The weight of her despair filled her like concrete. She thought about the one thing that the voice had told her that she couldn't shake: This has been your life for years. She pressed the tip of the blade against her skin, not enough to break it, but enough to feel a sting.

But the fear took over. Instead of pressing down, she threw the knife back into the drawer and slammed it shut. She let out a shaky breath and stumbled back into the kitchen. Her eyes landed on the wine bottle on the counter—maybe a glass-worth left. At least the wine was there for her. She clumsily progressed through her bed routine, forgetting to brush her teeth.

Alex passed out diagonally on top of her duvet still half clothed. She began dreaming of some of the key events of her life, seeing them unfold as if she was in the back of each room watching them unfold.

First, she dreamt she was back in primary school. One day in class, her teacher had asked each child what their favourite dinner was one by one. Alex didn't think anyone would notice her answer, until Andrew, the popular boy with the perfect hair, said, "Bangers and mash, with gravy."

Little Alex's eyes lit up. She had never liked sausages much, but she raised her hand and said, "I like that too!" with as much enthusiasm as she could muster. Adult Alex shook her head from the back of the classroom, her desperation for acceptance had started at an early age.

The teacher moved on, but Andrew turned in his seat and looked at her with a smirk, his hair perfectly style into a wave by his mother. He didn't say a word. He didn't need to. That look said everything—you don't belong here. And she'd never forgotten it.

The dream twisted, shifting to high school, where a thirteen-year-old Alex stood in the crowded lunchroom, clinging to her tray and scanning the tables for somewhere to sit which would be socially acceptable for all involved. High school felt like an unending gauntlet, where every glance felt like a judgment and every silence felt like a dismissal. She'd watch as her friends talked about the boys who'd texted them, boys who didn't even know Alex's name. Alex was constantly aware of her weight, of how her clothes fit differently, of how she always seemed... just a little off.

After lunch there was Biology class, the incident that would haunt her for years. They were showing a video of open-heart surgery, something about the way blood flowed through the

chambers. She'd tried to focus on taking notes, but the image of the heart beating, raw and pulsing, made her stomach twist. The room felt too hot. She could feel the sweat trickling down her back, her head swimming.

She remembered gripping the edge of her desk as her vision darkened. And then—nothing.

When she came to, she was on the floor, and the sound of laughter was already echoing around the room. She'd made a noise, a weird grunting sound as she'd passed out. She could still hear it as clearly as if she were still lying there, helpless on the cold floor, while the class erupted into laughter.

For the rest of high school, she was the girl who'd fainted in Biology. She'd hear kids making low grunting noises as she walked past, muffled laughter that would die down just enough for her to know it was about her. Some even went further: they'd mimic her, pretending to faint in the hallways, falling to the ground with exaggerated groans, or slumping against lockers with a theatrical sigh.

"Hey, careful, or Alex might pass out again," one of the boys had sneered during gym class, as she tried to avoid looking at him. Even teachers would look at her with poorly concealed pity, and their eyes would flicker with concern every time something remotely graphic was mentioned.

In her dream, Alex found felt something strange—a presence, lingering just out of view, like a shadow waiting to fully reveal itself. It followed her as she moved from scene to scene, flickering in the periphery of her vision, half-formed, like a figure coming together from the mist.

As each painful moment replayed, the shadow grew more defined, taking on a shape and an outline that unnervingly resembled her own. When she tried to run away from it, the presence only grew closer, more vivid, taking form as though nourished by each flicker of shame and hurt that played out before her in the dream.

By the time the dream shifted to the high school Biology classroom, the figure had solidified. Standing at the front of the class, looking polished and poised in a way Alex had never been,

was a version of herself. This version of Alex was everything she felt she should have been: prettier, slimmer, with an easy confidence that Alex had always fumbled to fake. Her hair was shinier, her clothes better-fitted, her skin flawless. She carried herself with a lightness that felt unattainable, her gaze holding a sharpness that cut straight through Alex's defences. The perfect reminder of all of her shortcomings.

Alex watched, horrified, as this other self watched the teenage version of her lying on the Biology classroom floor, hearing those horrible grunting sounds echo in the room and feeling the laughter and jeers pierce through her skin like needles. She could see her other self smiling, revelling in her humiliation, feeding off it, growing sharper and clearer with every humiliating memory. Her pain was food for this other self.

"You didn't think I was there all along?" Her voice was smooth and mocking, yet somehow calm, as if she had known this all along. "Oh, I was always here. Every time you tried to fit in, every time you failed and felt that sting of rejection—I was right there, becoming more real. All these years, Alex, I've been growing right alongside you."

"Remember Andrew?" the figure asked, her voice smooth and mocking. "Remember how you tried so hard to fit in that you lied about your favourite food just to impress him?" Her perfect, manicured eyebrow raised, and her mouth twisted into a smirk. "You didn't fool anyone, you know. They saw right through you. You were a joke even then."

Alex felt herself shrink, instinctively clutching her arms around herself protectively. The figure stepped closer to her at the back of the Biology classroom. "And then there's right here in high school. Remember that?" The figure's voice dropped to a whisper, the edges of her mouth lifting in a cruel smile. With a snap of her fingers, the dream distorted, and Alex found herself not watching the Biology scene, but on the floor herself staring up at the ceiling tiles, feeling the laughter ricochet off every corner of the room around and above her. Her chest tightened as she watched, helpless, hearing her own humiliating grunts fill the room, her classmates howling with laughter.

"You were pathetic," Other Alex said, her eyes bright and

merciless. "Every day, you fought to be accepted. But let's be real, Alex—who were you fooling?" Other Alex crouched down to meet Alex's gaze, her perfect beautiful smile sharp as a blade. "You never belonged. Not then, and not now."

The dream pivoted to earlier that night and the inner conflict Alex fought through. Alex and Other Alex were alone in the kitchen, standing facing each other on either side of a central kitchen island. The Swiss Army knife lay in the middle of the island, ready. Alex tried to look away, tried to block out the mocking figure. But her other self leaned closer, her smile twisting cruelly, her eyes gleaming with a dark amusement.

"I'm every insult you swallowed, every rejection you feared," Other Alex whispered, leaning in close. "I'm here because you created me."

Other Alex's form seemed to grow taller, stronger, casting a shadow up onto the ceiling as she continued.

"You made me," she said with quiet, vicious satisfaction. "And I'm not going anywhere."

Chapter 4

The following morning dawned grey and oppressive, matching the hideous hangover that greeted Alex when the alarm went off. "It can't actually be the morning yet," Alex said.

She trudged through her morning routine, each action mechanical, as if she were a marionette, strings pulled by a puppeteer whose heart was nowhere to be found. The after-effects of last night lingered.

Did last night really happen? The question gnawed at her. It's hard to be clear when your head is pounding.

At the office, the familiar hum of activity surrounded her as she settled at her desk. She glanced around the room, catching snippets of conversations and laughter that felt like personal attacks.

"Hey, Alex!" Phillip's cheerful voice broke through her reverie. "Ready for another day?"

"Sure," she replied, attempting to match his enthusiasm but failing miserably.

Phillip leaned closer, lowering his voice. "Listen, I know things have been tough. I talked to Karen about how you're getting on, but you're doing better than you think. Just remember, everyone has their struggles at the start." Does everyone feel as lost as I do? she wondered, but she didn't voice the question. Instead, she forced a smile and nodded, grateful for his kindness yet aware that her gesture felt inadequate.

While getting stuck into her new project, she finally felt like she was getting somewhere. She just focussed on getting the graphics looking as fresh and trendy for her client, Fabulous Fruits. She had, of course, been overlooked for Clean Green. The proportions were tricky. "How am I supposed to fit a pear and a pineapple into one logo," she muttered, though she was enjoying the challenge.

Her mind wandered to what Grace had said about her experience before Brightfield, piecing together snippets of

conversations they'd had. Grace had mentioned growing up in a small town, where everyone knew each other's business. "It was suffocating," she'd said. "Everyone expected you to fit into a mold."

Does she feel overwhelmed here, too? Alex wondered. The image of Grace, with her infectious laughter and genuine warmth, seemed too perfect, as if she had never known a moment of darkness. Perhaps that wasn't the case, and there was more to Grace than it first seemed.

During lunch, Alex spotted Grace across the room, animatedly chatting with a few colleagues. She seemed so at ease, so effortlessly social. You could be like that, the voice whispered. But you're not. You'll never be.

She picked at her food, the taste as bland as her logo for Fabulous Fruits. Just then, Michael sauntered by, his gaze landing on her with a smirk. "Still here, I see. Thought maybe you'd quit after yesterday's meltdown."

Rage filled her chest. Why does he get to have all the power? The resentment bubbled inside her, but she pushed it down. "Still here," she tersely replied, her voice barely masking her anger. "Good luck with that," he shot back, walking away with a swagger that infuriated her.

Why can't I just stand up to him?

As the week went on, her spirit began to fracture further. The incessant pressure from work, the need to please Karen, and the social entrapment compounded by Michael's taunts chipped away at her resolve. Out in the corridor, Alex could hear a conversation between Phillip and Grace. They were discussing a project they were working on together—Monkey Madness—and the camaraderie in their voices was palpable. It hurt to hear them so relaxed, so accepted, so at ease without overthinking every element of every moment and she couldn't shake the feeling of being an outsider, perpetually on the periphery. Grace's laughter echoed through the small space, and Alex clenched her fists, fighting the urge to cry. Why can't I have that?

That night, as she lay in bed memories of her childhood swirled

in her mind—moments of rejection and bullying that had carved deep scars in her psyche. You're worthless. You'll never be good enough. The voice echoed, relentless and cruel. She remembered being teased for her weight, for her shy demeanour. She recalled the time she was going to see a movie which was rated for ages fifteen and over. The group of girls were aged thirteen to fourteen so playing it cool at the movie theatre was of the upmost importance. They had invited Alex late on, and Andrea had been worried that she would be a liability and could cost the troop their underage entrance to the screening. There was always something, some reason that Alex felt like an outsider. WHY WAS IT ALWAYS LIKE THIS!

What if I just disappeared? For good? The thought was seductive, as if Other Alex was beckoning her closer.

Alex began to truly think and then began to write in her journal in bed. "There is so much evil in my thoughts. There was so much evil in the world, so much. Put on the news at any time and you are met with a bombardment of hurt and negativity. People treat each other so carelessly, causing so much pain and self-attack. If real evil exists, isn't it possible, even probable, even definite and necessary that the opposite exists?"

Alex recalled asking God to be with her as a little girl, though it seemed so silly now. She had just been parroting what she was told at Sunday school. Still, she had felt a comfort at the time. Alex called out in her bedroom: "If you're here, if you can hear me, if you're real, if you care, show me, please, please show me. I need help."

Nobody answered, but Alex recalled the time she had felt really sick with worry at school, she had to return to the room she fainted in during Biology for her form group class. She had asked for help, and she had gotten through it. Probably coincidence.

Alex felt the urge to continue writing in her journal, she got out of bed and started pouring her heart onto the pages. "I'm scared. I don't know how to keep going. I feel so lost. But I need to find my way back. I need help."

As the words flowed, she felt a small weight lift, the act of

writing a balm against the continuous pain of her life.

The following day, Alex made a decision. She would reach out to Grace, not just as a friend but as someone who might understand her struggles. Maybe we're not so different after all.

As she approached Grace at her desk, her heart raced, the vulnerability of the moment petrifying. "Hey, Grace, can we talk for a minute?"

"Of course!" Grace replied, her eyes brightening.

They stepped into a quieter corner of the office, and Alex took a deep breath. "I've been... struggling lately," she began, her voice trembling. "I don't know how to fit in, and I feel so lost." Grace's expression softened, and she nodded. "I thought you were maybe finding it tough. I may understand more than you think. I've had my share of struggles too."

As Grace opened up about her own struggles—her fight against the expectations of a small-town upbringing, the pressure to conform—Alex felt a connection forming, fragile but real. Maybe this is what I've been missing. It turned out Grace was estranged from her family, having come out as gay when she was a teenager. She had been at rock bottom and had to drop out of school. Without her saying it, Alex knew Grace had felt a similar dark temptation as she had. As Grace opened up to her about how she had lost touch with her parents when they couldn't accept her coming out, how she had to get a new start in a new city, Alex felt so close to her. Someone else who has truly suffered, who hasn't just walked the generic path of least resistance.

Holy crap, Grace's kindness isn't because she's never been through anything difficult, it's precisely because she has.

Chapter 5

Alex sat on the sofa that evening, buoyed by her newfound companionship in Grace. Taking this bit of motivation, she whipped out her journal.

Time to tackle Other Alex.

“Things are not hopeless,” Alex wrote. “I have a new friend in Grace. I am not alone. She has been hurt just like I have.” Why do you need a friend to feel comfortable at work? It’s just a job, my God you are so pathetic. You are addicted to validation from others because you never got what you needed growing up. You were always the outcast then and you always will be now. You are needy and pathetic.

Alex ignored Other Alex, the voice in her head, and pressed on with the journal: “Things are going better now. I have Fabulous Fruits to work on. Karen hasn’t said anything negative about my work on it yet, and things are finally starting to turn around. I can do this. I am doing this.”

Karen hasn’t even looked at your work because Fabulous is one of the smallest, least significant clients the office has. You didn’t get anywhere near Clean Green Tea, in case you hadn’t noticed. Not that that is any surprise.

“It’s time to do something about this. I’m going to find some self-help advice.”

Alex put away the journal and began her quest for liberation as so many do, the minefield of self-help.

Alex immediately went online and started searching for answers. She found some great sounding, highly recommended books. How to take control. How to own your destiny. How to be your best self. How to be confident in any situation. Alex bought them all.

A week later, Alex, like most self-help beginners, considered herself a self-help guru. It was all about taking ownership, taking control, seizing the day. There was some good advice in there of course and Alex felt hopeful, she finally had some ammo

to fire at her failure of a life.

Alex felt powerful and decided to confront Other Alex once more with her new mental arsenal. She wasn't quite so helpless now.

Journal out. Let's go.

"Why are you doing this? What is the point in causing me all this pain?"

I am not causing you pain. I AM pain. I am your build up and addiction to pain. Your addiction to alcohol. Your addiction to approval. I am the manifestation of your unmet needs. I am here because you made me. I am how you relate to the world. I am how you relate to others, and I am how you think of yourself. I am your reminder of your past. I am your prediction for the future, I am more you than you.

Alex sat and breathed slowly, counting the seconds during the inhale as Breathe and Win had taught her.

"I accept you. I have been trying to overcome you, to make you submit, to remove you, to separate from you. I can see that this only makes you stronger. You need to be heard. You must be. I hear you. I accept you. Stay and let's improve things together. You are my need for approval, my need to comfort myself with wine, my low self-esteem from all those old memories. My unmet needs. You are here and I am here, and we can both be here. Let's be a team."

Silence.

As Alex sat staring at her darkest inner self, her years of unchecked self-hatred, tears streamed down her face. She knew she was close to real progress. The image of her primary school self came to mind. She wasn't sure why.

Alex wrote to her child self, picturing everything she was writing. The room was small, neat with light blue walls and various classroom decoration—maps, flags and pictures completed by the class. Alex walked through the classroom door, observing the scene that had caused so much damage, innocuous though it seemed. She saw her child self put her hand up, so keen to be noticed. It was devastating. She saw the look from Andrew. Alex walked over to her child self and kneeled

down beside her. Everyone else in the room faded.

"Hey, listen. I know how much this hurt you. You just wanted to fit in. That's ok! It's totally normal to feel that way. I'm a grown up and still feel like that. But listen, you won't always belong where you are totally, and you definitely won't be liked by everyone, and that's how it's meant to be."

It is? Child Alex asked.

"Yes, because we are all different and some people get along and some don't. That's totally normal. Listen, you didn't need Andrew's approval. You have mine." Extending her hand to Child Alex, Alex said, "Come with me. You're safe with me, and I approve of you. I want you and I love you."

Child Alex took her hand, and the pair embraced. Child Alex was finally accepted. They walked out of the classroom together.

Alex was back in the room, feeling weightless. The extreme relief she felt gave her a moment of incredible clarity—all of her pain was self-inflicted. All of it. The strength of her emotions was overwhelming and made her laugh out loud. She kept laughing and laughing until more tears came, this time of relief. How absurd to fight with oneself, how incredibly destructive. Alex knew she had a long way to go. She also knew healing could be achieved. She went to bed sober for the first time in months.

Chapter 6

Morning arrived, shrouded in a thick fog that contradicted a newfound, tentative, sapling sense of optimism that awoke with Alex... She went through her usual routine, each action a little easier, a little lighter than the typically muddy and reluctant drudgery of the opening hours of a work morning. Alex mused on the night before, her breakthrough still at the peak of its healing powers. With this optimism, she went back through yesterday's conversation with Grace. I want to fight to make my mark. Grace was right. As the morning went on, Alex began her journey to Brightfield. The closer she got the more the buoyancy faded, the more the breakthrough lost its relevancy in her mind, the more the familiar dread set in. The suppressive sense of inadequacy, the ongoing social struggles pressing down on her like a suffocating blanket. The previous night's catharsis was a fantastic step, but still paled in comparison to two decades of built-up trauma.

As she entered the office, the atmosphere felt charged with a mixture of anticipation and anxiety. The team was gearing up for a big presentation, and the stakes were high. Just another day to prove you don't belong here, the nagging voice whispered. Settling at her desk, she noticed the gleaming faces of her colleagues, each one bustling with energy, preparing to shine. But all Alex felt was a gnawing sense of inadequacy. As she skimmed through her tasks, she couldn't shake the feeling that she was running behind, perpetually two steps away from catching up.

Michael walked by, casting a glance at her screen. "You know we're all counting on you, right?" His voice dripped with mockery. "Hope you can keep up this time."

Alex clenched her jaw, the frustration boiling beneath her surface. Why does he always have to be like this? She took a deep breath, fighting the urge to retaliate. "I'll do my best," she managed to reply, though the words tasted bitter on her tongue.

The day unfolded in a blur of meetings, each one tightening the noose around her spirit. Ms. Allen was particularly demanding,

pointing out every mistake, every oversight. "Alex, this report is subpar. We need you to elevate your work, not drag it down, I mean it's just...drab. This is Brightfield. Not Drabfield" she snapped, her voice slicing through the air.

The shame washed over Alex, hot and stinging. You're failing. The internal dialogue spiralled out of control, drowning out any glimmer of hope. You're worthless. You'll never be enough.

At lunch, she found herself sitting alone, her appetite vanished. She picked at her food, the sounds of laughter and conversation around her fading into a dull roar. Why can't you be more like them? The thought stung, and she squeezed her eyes shut, willing the tears to stay at bay.

Grace spotted her from across the room and made her way over, a bright smile illuminating her face. "Mind if I join you?"

Alex forced a smile in return. "Sure."

Grace settled into the chair opposite her, her expression shifting to one of concern. "You look stressed. What's going on?" "I don't know," Alex admitted, her voice trembling. "I just feel... lost. Every time I try to keep up, it feels like I'm falling behind. I've even been reading all these self-help books about mindset, muting anxiety triggers, being more confident and being ok with who I am, and some of it really helped, but I just keep ending up back where I started, I don't feel that the change is lasting, I don't feel like it's enough, I don't feel like it's giving me a direction, just helping me cope. Maybe I need to do more of it I don't know Grace..."

Grace leaned forward, her brow furrowing. "I get that. I felt that way too, especially when I first started. But you're so much stronger than you think. You just need to find your footing. I have some thoughts on all the self-help stuff too, but maybe another time would be better for that. You've got this let's focus on today."

Stronger. The word echoed in Alex's mind, but it felt like a lie. "But what if I can't?" she whispered, the vulnerability breaking through her defences.

"You can," Grace insisted, her voice steady. "You're not in this

alone, remember?”

Not alone. The thought was a lifeline, a flicker of light in the consuming darkness. But just as quickly, the self-doubt surged back. You’re just going to disappoint everyone.

After lunch, the afternoon dragged on like a slow march to an execution. Each task felt more insurmountable than the last. By the time the presentation was due to start, panic was the dominant force in her mind and body.

As they gathered in the conference room, Alex’s palms were slick with sweat, her mind a whirlwind. What if I mess up? What if they see how unprepared I am? She shifted in her seat, Michael’s earlier words ping ponging around her brain.

The presentation began, and Alex fought to concentrate, but the self-doubt clawed at her. When it was her turn to speak, her throat tightened. She stood, clutching her notes as though they were a lifeline. Her leg was shaking, she tried to plant her foot into the floor to steady it.

As she spoke her voice trembled. The words felt foreign, slipping through her fingers like sand. She caught Michael’s eye; he smirked, a triumphant gleam in his gaze. You’re failing.

Suddenly the room felt too small, the air too thick. She stumbled over her words, her heart pounding as the weight of everyone’s expectations crashed over her. The presentation ended, and as the team filed out, she felt like a ghost—a fraction of the person she wished she could be.

In the aftermath, she retreated to the restroom, leaning against the cold tiles. You’re a disappointment. You let them all down. Well except your peers, they loved it. Now they’re even further ahead. The internal voice mocked her mercilessly. Tears returned to her cheeks once again, and she pressed her fingertips against her eyes, willing the pain to stop.

Then, a quiet voice broke through the chaos. “Alex? Are you okay?”

Startled, Alex looked up to see Grace standing in the doorway, her expression a mix of concern and determination. “I just saw you come in here, and I thought...”

"I can't do this," Alex choked out. "I can't keep up with everyone's expectations. I feel like I'm drowning."

Grace stepped closer, her presence a comforting balm against Alex's turmoil. "You're not drowning. You're just wading through deep waters right now. It's okay to struggle, but you have to let people in. You don't have to carry this alone."

Let people in. The concept felt terrifying and liberating all at once. "I don't want to be a burden."

Grace shook her head vigorously. "You're not a burden. We all need help sometimes. That's what makes us human."

In that moment, something within Alex shifted. She felt a crack forming in the walls she had built around herself. "I've been so focused on proving I belong here that I've forgotten what it means to be real."

"That's part of the journey," Grace said gently. "You're learning. It's messy, but it's also beautiful."

As the words sank in, Alex felt a flicker of understanding ignite within her. Maybe I can find my way back. Maybe I can redefine what success means for me.

They stood in the restroom, the air thick with unspoken emotions. "Thank you for always being there," Alex whispered, her voice trembling with gratitude.

"Always," Grace replied, a smile breaking through the tension.

As they left the restroom, Alex felt a new resolve forming within her. The journey ahead would be long and fraught with challenges, but with Grace by her side, perhaps she could face them.

Maybe I don't have to have it all figured out. Maybe it's okay to struggle, as long as I keep moving forward.

With Grace by her side, Alex took a step into the unknown, ready to embrace the messiness of her journey.

The next morning dawned crisp and bright. A new day, Alex thought while stirring her coffee, though a familiar apprehension lingered.

As she prepared for work, Alex found herself mentally rehearsing her goals for the day. No more letting Michael's or anyone else's words dictate my worth. Today, I'll focus on my own progress. The morning routine felt different; each small action—a splash of water on her face, the scent of coffee brewing—was a reminder that life continued to move forward. That she was moving forward.

When she arrived at the office a few minutes early, she noticed a shift within herself. Instead of immediately heading to her desk, she made her way to the break room. I can't keep isolating myself.

The chatter of her colleagues buzzed in the background as she poured herself a cup of coffee. To her surprise, Grace was already there, animatedly discussing Monkey Madness with Mark and a few others.

"Hey, Alex!" Grace called out, her eyes brightening. "Come join us!"

For a moment, Alex hesitated, the instinct to retreat pulling at her. But she squared her shoulders, took a deep breath, and walked over. The energy of the group was infectious, and as they laughed, something inside her began to thaw.

"What do you think about the new client proposal?" Mark asked, his gaze shifting to Alex. They had chatted through Monkey—a children's tropical fruit drink Grace and Mark were working on—and were tasked with coming up with the branding to wrap around the cartons.

"Honestly? I think we need to be more aggressive with our pitch," Alex said while looking at the milquetoast mock up, surprising even herself with her confidence. "If we don't stand out, they'll overlook us and wonder what they're paying for over and above any other kid's drink"

Grace nodded vigorously, and Mark raised an eyebrow, impressed. "Exactly! I love that perspective. You should share it in the next team meeting."

Maybe I can do this, Alex thought, a flicker of hope igniting within her. Maybe I belong here.

The morning passed in a blur of tasks and meetings, and for the first time Alex felt like she was keeping pace. Her colleagues began to notice her contributions, and she could sense a shift in their attitudes. Even Michael seemed less antagonistic, though she knew better than to let her guard down completely.

During the lunch break, she found herself sitting with Grace and a few others, engaging in easy banter. They shared stories from their weekends, Mark's ongoing quest for a decent date being the centrepiece. Alex found herself laughing—a sound that had felt foreign for far too long. This is what it feels like to connect.

But as the conversation turned to next weekend plans, Alex felt a pang of anxiety. What about me? She had become so consumed by work that she had forgotten how to socialize outside of it. "I might just catch up on some reading," she said, trying to play it off.

"Oh, come on! You should join us," Grace urged, her enthusiasm palpable. "We're planning a hike. Fresh air will do you good."

Fresh air. The thought felt appealing, yet terrifying. What if I can't keep up, these guys are actively choosing to exercise so they're probably way fitter than me, I'll probably hold them back and embarrass myself. But the longing for connection overpowered her fears. "Okay. I'll come," she said as if she was doing them a favour, surprising herself in the process.

The rest of the afternoon dragged, but Alex found herself anticipating the weekend. The prospect of stepping outside her comfort zone felt invigorating, uncomfortable though it was.

As the workday ended, Alex gathered her things, her heart pounding with a mixture of excitement and anxiety. What if they regret inviting me? What if I ruin it?

That night, she lay in bed, her thoughts swirling. She picked up her journal and began to write. "I'm scared of the hike. I'm scared I won't be able to keep pace, to fit in, to not be the pudgy unfit one, to embarrass myself. But I want to try. I want to break these walls I've built around myself."

The words poured out, each sentence a release of the tension she had been holding. As she finished writing, she closed her

journal and had a sudden recollection of the incident at the cinema. This was very similar, she was worried she was going to somehow ruin it for everyone and be labelled for it.

Journal re-opened, Alex decided to go to that part of herself the same way as she had to her child self in the classroom. Alex began to write, picturing the scene vividly.

She saw Andrea telling the girls that inviting Alex was a mistake, that she wasn't cool and would get them rejected from the movie because she couldn't pull it off. Alex watched the scene play out before walking over to her teenage self.

"Hey, Andrea had no idea what she was saying," Alex said. "You actually ended up getting into the movie just fine. In fact they were probably the least suspicious of you. You were a new friend to the group and maybe Andrea just felt a bit threatened about her position in the group. I think you're cool, I want you with me, and I accept you. You don't need Andrea anymore. You have me and always will. Come with me."

The scene faded as Alex put her pen down. Again the weightlessness was overwhelming, Alex started laughing again and could feel the decoupling from her demons.

Chapter 7

On Saturday morning, Alex woke up early, mind racing with anticipation of the hike. An extra coffee would be essential. She dressed in comfortable clothes, packing a small backpack with water and snacks, all while reminding herself that this was a step toward connection. You're not alone. You're not a burden.

When she arrived at the meeting spot, the sun was shining brightly, and the air was crisp. Grace was already there, chatting with Mark, Sam, and Helen.

"Hey, you made it!" Grace exclaimed, rushing over to hug her. "We were starting to worry!"

"I wouldn't miss it," Alex replied, her confidence growing as she joined the group.

They set off on the trail, laughter echoing through the surrounding trees. Alex felt lighter with each step, the cool breeze carrying away some of her heaviness. The conversation flowed easily, and she found herself sharing stories of her childhood—embarrassing moments and triumphs that seemed so distant now.

"Wait, you used to hide in the bathroom during school?" Mark teased, a playful grin on his face. "Yeah, I just needed to escape sometimes," Alex admitted, chuckling at the memory. "That toilet was my sanctuary."

This drew a good laugh from everyone.

"That's relatable," Grace said. "We all have our ways of coping. I used to sneak out at lunchtime to get some space."

As they continued along the path, the easy banter began to fill the gaps that loneliness had carved.

At the end of the hike, the group gathered at a scenic overlook, the view sprawling out like a beautiful tapestry. As the sun dipped lower in the sky, casting golden hues across the landscape, Alex took a moment to breathe it in.

This is what it means to be alive, she thought, her heart swelling

with gratitude for the feeling of acceptance.

As they all snapped photos and shared laughs, Alex realized that this day was more than just a hike; it was a turning point. She felt a deeper connection to her colleagues and to herself, a burgeoning sense of belonging that had been missing for so long.

That evening, as she lay in bed reflecting on the day. What a perfect day, it really couldn't have gone any better. Maybe I can keep doing this—embracing the challenges, allowing myself to be vulnerable, and letting others in.

With her journal in hand, she began to write again. "Today was wonderful, all my worries were completely unfounded. I am starting to accept myself bit by bit and its really helping with my work and socially."

The days following the hike passed with a strange mix of clarity and confusion. Alex felt buoyed by the camaraderie she had experienced, yet her insecurities lingered, intertwined with her newfound optimism like poison ivy around an otherwise lovely trellis.

One afternoon the following week, as she settled into her work, she felt a flicker of unease. What if this is just a facade? The thought gnawed at her, pushing its way to the forefront of her mind. Things never go this smoothly, the other shoe will drop at any moment. Grace is bound to give up on me and I am certainly overdue a critique from Hannah or Karen.

Just then, Ms. Allen called for a team meeting on Fantastic Fruits. Alex's heart sank. The prospect of being scrutinized in front of everyone felt overwhelming. As they gathered in the conference room, Alex noticed the usual buzz was absent, there was an umbrella of tension over the room.

"Alright, team," Ms. Allen began, her voice sharp. "We need to discuss our upcoming client meeting. I expect everyone to bring their A-game."

As she continued, Alex felt her heart race. A-game? What if I don't even know what that means for me? What if instead of Fantastic Fruits I deliver a Fantastic Failure, Ms. Allen does love

a pun... She glanced around the room, noticing how everyone seemed so confident, so assured. Michael was leaning back in his chair, a smirk playing on his lips.

"Alex, I hope you've done your homework," Ms. Allen said, cutting into her thoughts. "We can't afford any slip-ups this time. I expect that branding to be ready and on trend."

The words hit her like a physical blow. Slip ups. She felt the room close in around her, her throat tightening. "I—I'm working on it," she managed to stammer, though the tremor in her voice betrayed her.

After the meeting, Alex retreated to her desk, the weight of her potential inadequacy crushing her spirit. You're not good enough. She opened her laptop, but the words blurred together, the screen threatened her.

"Hey, you okay?" Grace's voice broke through her fog, and Alex looked up to find her new friend hovering nearby.

"I just... I can't shake this feeling that I'm going to blow this client," Alex admitted, her voice barely a whisper.

Grace's brow furrowed with concern. "You've been doing great. Don't let one meeting overshadow all the progress you've made. Besides Ms. Allen has a permanent stick up her ass. It's not about you."

"But it feels like every time I take one step forward, I'm shoved back two," Alex said, the frustration bubbling to the surface. "I don't understand why I'm being treated like this."

Grace sighed, her expression softening. "I know it's tough, but you have to remember that some people are who they are. It's not a reflection of your worth. You're learning and growing, and that's what matters."

Learning and growing. The words resonated with Alex, but the deep-seated doubt still festered. "What if I can't grow? What if I'm stuck like this forever?"

Grace placed a hand on her shoulder, a gesture of solidarity. "You're not stuck, Alex. You're on a journey, and it's okay to be scared. Just don't let fear dictate your worth."

As the afternoon wore on, Alex found herself plagued by thoughts of the meeting. She stared at her screen, but all she could see were the faces of her colleagues, their judgmental expressions playing in her mind like a cruel movie reel. What if they see me as a failure? What if I can't make it? What if I... what was it..." slip up" as usual.

Finally, she decided to take a break, needing air to clear her head. She wandered up to the office balcony on the top floor, seeking solace in the open sky.

As she leaned against the railing, the wind whipped through her hair, carrying away some of her pent-up frustration. She closed her eyes, allowing herself to breathe deeply. Maybe this is just a phase. Maybe I can find a way through this. I need to remember the positive steps lately. I am starting to fit in better. I will show Ms.Allen I can do this.

She heard footsteps as someone had come onto the balcony. Turning, she saw Grace had joined her, a sympathetic smile on her face. "Mind if I keep you company?"

"Not at all," Alex replied, grateful for her friend's unwavering and unearned support.

They stood in silence for a moment, gazing out at the sprawling city below. "I don't know how to shake this feeling," Alex admitted, her voice trembling. "It's like I'm walking on a tightrope, and one misstep will send me crashing down."

Grace nodded thoughtfully. "That's understandable. You're carrying a lot of pressure. But you need to be gentle with yourself. Progress isn't linear. It's okay to falter."

"I just wish it didn't feel so heavy," Alex confessed, the vulnerability spilling out. "Every day feels like a battle against my own mind."

"Sometimes, the hardest battles are the ones we fight within ourselves," Grace said softly.

As Alex looked at her friend, she felt a surge of gratitude. "Thank you for being here, Grace. I don't know what I'd do without you."

"You don't have to do this alone," Grace reassured her.
"Remember, it's okay to lean on others."

When they returned to the office, the familiar chaos awaited them. But Alex felt lighter after the conversation on the balcony. She approached her desk with renewed determination, vowing to tackle her work with a fresh perspective.

But as the day continued, the cracks in her facade began to show. Despite Grace's support, the relentless tide of self-doubt threatened to pull her under once more.

One evening, as she sat alone in her apartment, Alex received a message from Grace: "Hey, how about dinner tomorrow? Just us?"

The idea was comforting, and for the first time in days Alex felt a spark of excitement. "Sure! That sounds great," she replied, her spirits lifting. The next evening, they met at a cozy Italian restaurant renowned for its spicy tomato pasta, the dim lighting and soft music providing a warm atmosphere. They ordered food and settled into conversation, allowing the tension of the week to melt away.

"Tell me more about what you are going through," Grace prompted, her eyes sparkling with curiosity.

Taking a deep breath, Alex opened up. "It's been hard. I feel like I'm constantly battling my own demons. Some days, I feel like I'm making progress, and others... it's just overwhelming."

Grace listened intently, nodding. "You're so much stronger than you realize. Remember, it's okay to struggle, but don't lose sight of how far you've come. You're at a top firm loads of people would kill to have a chance at, and you have your own apartment. You aren't thinking of how successful you are compared to a lot of people"

"I know, but sometimes it feels like I'm just pretending to be okay," Alex admitted, her voice quavering. "What if everyone else sees through the facade?"

"Then let them see," Grace said. "You're human. You're allowed to have bad days. Just don't forget that you have people who care about you. Listen I don't want you to be weirded out, but I

wanted to talk to you about something, something that helped me a lot. When you mentioned the self-help struggles, how it did help a bit but didn't get to the root, I wanted to go into then and there but felt we needed more time to chat."

"Please fire away. All help much appreciated!"

"Okay, well for the longest time I struggled. I've never told you just how badly, but Alex, I got to a really low point when my parents disowned me. It's hard to just say this, but I think you need to hear it: I was thinking about ending it all. I just couldn't see a way forward. My family wanted nothing to do with me, I felt rejected by society, and I hated myself." Grace started to tear up.

"Are you okay?" Alex asked, concerned.

"Yea. It's just hard to talk about, even now, but I want to share this with you. I felt completely alone. Completely rejected. But I noticed that every time I thought of doing something stupid, when I was at my worst, something happened or a thought would come that would stop me. When I really thought about it, I felt like something has been protecting me and that same thing been with me all of my life. I've always thought about the big questions in life, why are we here, what's my purpose, is there a purpose? And I came to really believe that there is absolutely good in the world and absolutely evil. And if that is true, what does that mean? Who made the rules? Why is it when we watch a truly inspiring scene in a movie, or hear a beautiful song, do we get touched emotionally? Why does it resonate so strongly? With what does it resonate? I believe there is more to us than just our day-to-day selves and that part of us that is more resonates with these things. You know what I mean? Like when you see something so inspiring and it makes you realise how small your thinking is? How trivial? What you could be and should be doing with your life? Like what is that, you know?"

Alex nodded along, captivated, the obvious truth of Grace's speech fully gripping her.

"So I basically believed that there is good and evil, that we are more than our day-to-day selves, and that we have purpose—otherwise we wouldn't resonate with things that inspire us. All

of that coupled with my sense that someone or something had been watching over me made me fairly sure we aren't alone, that there is a higher power and it's our job to seek that out." "Look I know I'm rambling on here, but I remember being given a copy of the Gospels when I was out shopping. I laughed it off and see those people in the street as mild lunatics, but for some reason I took the paper copy home. Anyways I read them, and I was shocked—the messages in there acted as confirmation of the conclusions I had already arrived at. It explains everything really, why the world is what it is, why we are so easily tempted, why we want to be better but struggle so much to achieve it. Basically Alex, I believe God saved me, and I want to live according to the values he has set. Since doing so, I have still had bad days and struggled, but I have felt an immense sense of purpose that I didn't have before, I know why I am here. I couldn't not talk to you about this."

Alex had no idea what to say, so she just said, "Thank you very much for sharing that with me."

Grace pulled some paper out of her pocket and gave it to Alex. "This is those same Gospels, just those bits. Do whatever you think is right, but I recommend having a read and seeing if it resonates."

As the evening was coming to a close, Alex was keen to get home and read the Gospels. If it had made such a difference to Grace's life, it was worth a look at least. Why not?

Alex read the four Gospels from start to finish. She was blown away by what she was reading, parts of the text seemed like they had been written just for her.

Alex found herself holding the small, crinkled paper she had taken from Grace. She couldn't shake the strange feeling that had settled in her chest as she turned the pages. The words of Jesus were more than words on a page. They were truths that touched her deeply and cut to her core. What did that resonance mean?

There had always been something missing in her life. She couldn't deny that. Every decision, every new phase, each moment of doubt—it had all been clouded by a gnawing sense of

emptiness. Alex had always questioned her purpose, wondering if there was more to her existence than just floating through life, picking up pieces of happiness here and there amongst the trash heap that was her life. She had never been able to find a firm direction—no north star to guide her. The satisfaction and completeness she longed for always seemed just out of reach. But now, as she reflected on Grace's words and what she had read, it was like a light had flicked on in the deepest, most fundamental parts of her.

She remembered the moments when she had felt watched over, protected, as if some invisible force was steering her away from dangers or giving her little nudges at just the right time. She'd written those experiences off before, thinking them to be mere coincidence, but now, those moments took on a new meaning. It wasn't random—it had never been random. She was not alone. Someone had always been there.

And then the truth of it all hit her, a realization so profound that it left her breathless. The life she had been living, one of aimless striving, was filled with dissonance because she had been trying to live without knowing the why. She had lacked a foundation, a guiding principle, a north star. It wasn't just about finding good or evil, about yearning for purpose—it was about following a truth, a divine truth that had been here all along. The Gospels had opened her eyes to that, to the undeniable power of Jesus's words. The way He spoke of love, forgiveness, and grace, of redemption—it resonated completely. She had been waiting for someone to show her the way, and through the gift of her new friend she had found it.

Alex sat there, stunned by the clarity of it all. The dissatisfaction she had felt for years, the struggle to make sense of the chaos and pain in her life—it all made sense now. Her self-obsession had been her blindfold, her golden cow, and her greatest obstacle. The way Jesus spoke of peace and a life led by love, the way He had walked through the world offering healing to everyone He encountered—it wasn't just a set of rules or ancient history. It was a blueprint for living, and it was everything she had been searching for without even knowing it.

She finally understood. She hadn't been wandering aimlessly at all; she had been led. Every moment, every doubt, every joy—it

had been part of a larger, divinely orchestrated plan. And now, as she felt the weight of that truth settle deep within her, Alex knew one thing for certain: this wasn't just an idea to ponder or an abstract truth to admire. This was a call to action.

Her dissatisfaction, her aimlessness—it had all stemmed from the absence of that one thing. The truth she had stumbled upon in the Gospels wasn't just comforting; it was life-changing. With this newfound understanding, Alex felt a sense of direction for the first time. A sense of purpose. She wasn't just surviving anymore—she was called to live differently, to live in alignment with a higher truth.

She closed the pages of the Gospels, feeling an overwhelming sense of peace for the first time in ages. Jesus's words had done more than speak to her—they had softened her heart. She wasn't alone. She never had been.

Chapter 8

The incredible revelations Alex had felt and known to be true had already changed her. However as it is designed, the world is very good at pulling the wool over our eyes with seemingly vital distractions. As such, as Alex was thrust back into the fray of her busy work life, the usual shallow distractions of anticipation, anxiety and dread wormed their way back to the forefront of Alex's awareness.. The office buzzed with the energy of the impending client meeting, but Alex felt increasingly anxious as the day approached to present her final work on Fabulous Fruits. Her insecurities loomed large, whispering that she was an imposter, that she would once again stumble in front of everyone. What if I freeze? What if I let them down?

Each morning, she would sit at her desk, performing the ritual of rehearsing what she would say in her head. But the closer the meeting came, the more overwhelmed she felt. Her stomach churned, and the dread settled in like a heavy weight.

In the break room, Grace found her staring blankly at a cup of coffee, lost in thought. "You okay?" she asked gently.

"I don't know. I feel like I'm going to mess everything up," Alex replied, her voice tinged with desperation. Grace leaned against the counter, crossing her arms. "You've prepared, and you've done the work. Just be yourself. Remember, you're not alone in this. We're all a team."

"Yeah, but what if I'm the weak link?" Alex's voice trembled, and she looked down, unable to meet Grace's gaze.

"Then you learn from it," Grace said firmly. "None of us are perfect, and that's what makes us human. You have so much to offer. Don't let fear overshadow that."

Taking a deep breath, Alex nodded, though the tightness in her chest remained. I have to push through this, she thought. I can't let fear of Ms. Allen's criticism control me.

The day of the meeting had arrived, the tension in the office was palpable. Colleagues rushed around, finalizing presentations and strategizing. Alex found herself pacing back and forth,

anxiety bubbling up and out of her.

In the conference room, the atmosphere was charged. Ms. Allen took the lead, directing the meeting with her usual authoritative presence. Alex sat at the table with her teammates, feeling small and insignificant amidst the clamour of voices.

“Let’s make sure everyone is up to speed and is ready to deliver,” Ms. Allen said, looking pointedly at Alex. “Alex, you’ll present first on your work with the branding.”

“Of course,” Alex replied, her voice barely above a whisper. The choking sense of expectation pressed heavily on her shoulders, and the air felt thick with unspoken judgments.

As Ms. Allen continued her rundown of the meeting itinerary, Alex found herself retreating into her chair. What if I falter? What if they laugh at me? The doubt wrapped around her like a vice, suffocating her.

Finally, it was time for her to present. The room went quiet as she stood, her hands shaking as she clicked through her slides. She felt the eyes of her colleagues on her, piercing and critical. The more she spoke, the more her voice wavered, her confidence slipping away like sand through her fingers.

“I—I believe we can achieve a significant portion of market share with this branding. It’s bold and is something different to our competitors,” she stammered, struggling to keep her composure whilst showing her off her cartoon fruit packaging.

Just as she finished, she caught Michael’s eye, and the disdain etched on his face sent her heart plummeting. “Is that all you have?” he sneered, his voice cutting through the silence. “You just prepared one option? Surely you made some comparative designs for us all to consider?”

Shame washed over her, hot and suffocating. The room felt like it was closing in, her colleagues’ gazes turning sharp and critical. Why do I even try?

Ms. Allen quickly stepped in, her tone sharp. “Michael, that’s enough. We’re here to support each other, not tear each other down.”

But the damage was done. Alex felt her cheeks burn, tears prickling at the corners of her eyes. She stumbled back to her seat, the walls of her world closing in once more. The whispers around her felt like daggers.

After the meeting, Alex rushed to the bathroom, needing to escape. She leaned against the cold tile wall, her heart pounding. Why did I think I could do this? The tears she had held back flooded forth, and she sank to the floor, her body shaking with sobs.

In that moment of vulnerability, the weight of everything she had been carrying crushed her. The shame, the fear, the relentless pressure to prove herself—it all coalesced into a singular feeling of despair. I'm not strong enough for this.

You're right, you're not sneered sneered Other Alex.

Just as she thought she would drown in the darkness, her phone buzzed in her pocket. Wiping her tears, she fumbled to check it. It was a message from Grace: "Hey, just checking in. You did great in there. I'm proud of you. Let's grab lunch?"

Alex hesitated, the thought of facing the world again feeling daunting. But another message popped up: "Remember, you're not alone. I'm here for you."

Taking a deep breath, Alex texted back, "Okay. I'll be there soon."

As she walked back into the office, she felt hollow, but the promise of companionship gave her a sliver of hope. She met Grace in the break room, and her friend's warm smile enveloped her like a balm.

"You okay?" Grace asked gently, concern etched in her features.

"No," Alex admitted, her voice breaking. "I feel like I completely failed. I can't do this."

Grace wrapped her arms around her, and Alex leaned into the embrace, feeling the warmth of friendship envelop her. "You're going to have setbacks. That doesn't define your worth. You're brave for even stepping up to present."

"But Michael... he just makes everything worse," Alex murmured, her throat tightening.

"Michael is a bully," Grace said firmly. "Don't let him dictate your value. But honestly? It would be normal to prepare a few options. How come you didn't?"

Alex knew she was right. "I guess I have been so wrapped up in how I felt that it affected my work. My focus has been too divided."

"Look I don't know how you felt about everything I said the other night, but there's something I have come to realise: you could look at this as literally a spiritual truth or just a mental model. It works either way. So basically, if you are so obsessed with how you feel and what everyone else thinks, you are essentially worshipping them in that they are occupying the top spot in your hierarchy of what is important to you. You become completely self absorbed, under the spell of your own story. For me this is Grace's woes, Grace's life, Grace's needs, Grace's relationships. There is little room left to focus on what really matters. Christians call this idolatry, but it doesn't have to be a golden cow. It can be anything or anyone that occupies your mind and heart and takes your focus away from what is most important. This is why we are told to seek first the Kingdom of Heaven. This is what I think Jesus meant when he said "deny yourself, pick up your cross and follow me" It could read as "deny yourself", your impulses and shallow desires which contradict your higher values. But it could also be read as "deny your self", which I really like because it would mean Jesus is warning against this very issue, our tendency to worship our own story, our own wants, our egoic involuntary whims. When we do this, we are like a paper bag in the wind, at the mercy of whatever life throws at us, always reacting, never centered, never focussed, never aligned with anything solid. Whatever you ultimately believe I have found this is a great way to look at things, it really helped me get over my own issues, to look past my personal pain and realise that there is something more important. To stop being a slave to my self administered mental chains."

"It is a sin in Christianity for this reason as you are not giving God his rightful place in your life. However, even if you just look

at this as a mental model, you only have so much focus. If we say you have one hundred focus points, if ninety of those are on your work trauma and where you stand with various people, there is just ten points less for the rest of your life. You cannot thrive in these conditions."

Alex began to laugh. "Grace I am so lucky to have met you. How do you come up with this stuff."

"I don't. I am guided by the Holy Spirit. Without Him, I would be lost in my own mind too. In fact I still am a lot of the time. So what did you think about what we talked about? Did you get reading any of it?"

"Yea," Alex said. "I read all of it and it made a lot of sense. I could feel there was truth there beyond just a logical agreement with what was written. I have so many questions, but I can feel a strong pull towards the texts. A connection."

"Great," Grace said. "That is the Holy Spirit providing you with a bit of guidance. Learn to listen to that intuition. Yea, you will always have questions—I still have a lot and still have doubts—but I know there is a core truth there. Next is to get a copy of the Bible and read more, as you do your understanding will grow. It's better to just read, as the Holy Spirit will enable you to discern the truth as you read. I mean I know my insight on idolatry came from the Holy Spirit. It's that ability to connect the spiritual wisdom to the every day that can change your life. It changed mine."

That evening, Alex's phone buzzed with a call from an unknown number. With reluctance, she answered. "Hello?"

"Alex? It's Melissa," came the cheerful voice of her old school friend. "I found your number through Facebook. How have you been?"

The sudden transportation to the mental place she was in at school, sparked by her old friend's voice caused Alex to have a moment of bodily panic, however Alex remembered Melissa well, one of the few girls she had bonded with in that time, Melissa had somehow not been consumed with the social ladder at that age. Alex found herself opening up about her struggles. "Hey, Melissa. It's been a long time! It's really good to hear

from you. It's been tough, honestly. I'm dealing with some... work issues."

"Work issues?" Melissa chuckled lightly. "That sounds familiar. Remember the drama we had in high school?"

Alex laughed, a small smile breaking through her gloom. "Oh, how could I forget? You were always the one who stood up to those bullies."

"Someone had to!" Melissa said, her tone turning more serious. "So yea...I'm getting married this winter and wanted to invite you."

"You are? Who's the guy? Tell me everything. Immediately."

"It's Jared! You know that cocky guy who thought he was smarter than everyone else? Well, yea...I learned to overlook that, and I'm just so happy."

"Jared! I can't believe it. We used to make poems about him... 'I think I'm so smart, a pure piece of art, my name is Jared, and I smell my own farts.'"

They both burst into laughter.

"Yes, that Jared. He's really great. So, you coming?"

Despite the panic over having to find something to wear and having no one to go with, Alex agreed. "Of course I am. Thanks for calling."

After they hung up, Alex sat quietly in her living room, happy to have heard from her old friend. Alex pondered Grace's words on idolatry. It made so much sense. So what's the solution? she wondered. I need a practise. I need to fill my life with what matters so that I am not totally occupied by nonsense.

The following day, Alex walked into the office with a renewed determination. She had spent the night reflecting on her journey, the struggles that had shaped her, and the strength she had yet to uncover.

When she first encountered Michael that morning, Alex was surprised by her reaction. Instead of shrinking away, she met his gaze with newfound resilience. "Thanks for your feedback at the

Fabulous Fruits meeting. I look forward to working with you on it.”

Alex walked away before he could respond. The look on Michael’s face was one of surprise. This wasn’t the norm, and for the first time since they had met at the day one induction, Alex felt a flicker of empowerment as she walked away. I can stand up for myself.

As the day unfolded, the sense of victory was fading slowly like a cup of tea slowly losing its heat. Alex began to lean into her long-curated habit of the discomfort. She was much happier than she had been but could feel herself sliding into her natural habitat of self-doubt. Thoughts of Ms. Allen occupied her mind. She was also expecting to get a rap on the knuckles from Karen for her poor presentation and under-prepared branding. The more she thought about it all, the more the peace she had been accumulating dissipated.

Her conviction on the Gospels was now tangled with a sense of doubt. It had all felt so true, so real—too real. But was it? Or had she just wanted it to be true so badly that she had convinced herself? Alex ran her fingers over the pages of the Gospels again. Was this really the truth? Or was it just a comfort, a story that filled the emptiness inside her for the moment?

Back at home, she needed to clear her head, to think, to pray. With a deep breath, Alex laced up her sneakers and headed out the door. A run. It was always the best way for her to think things through, to find clarity. The cold air hit her face as she started, her feet pounding the pavement, her thoughts racing even faster than her body.

“God, are You really there? Is this real?” Alex found herself speaking out loud, though there was no one around to hear. She could feel the words rise in her chest as if they had been building there for days.

“God, I want this to be real. I want to believe so badly... but how do I know for sure? How do I know this is more than just... something I need, something I wish for? She pushed herself harder, the pavement clicking away beneath her. She kept running, breathing in the cool evening air, praying the way she

knew how—simply, honestly, even if it felt like her heart was still a little broken, still a little unsure. Even if she didn't really feel like she had the right to talk to Him. What if she was just imagining it all? What if this was nothing more than a fleeting thought, a phase that would pass like all the others? Another form of flawed self-help?

And then, as she rounded a bend in the path on her way back home, something caught her eye. She looked up, and there was an unmistakable gap in the thick grey clouds of the cold evening. That gap was subtle but was unquestioningly in the shape of a cross. She blinked, unsure if she was seeing things.

But there it was. A subtle but unmistakable shape—a cross. The clouds around it remained completely still. It wasn't bold. It wasn't obvious—just a fleeting, delicate image in the sky. But it was there, hovering, clear enough to stop her in her tracks.

Alex froze, her breath catching in her throat. Her heart skipped a beat. She stared at the cross in the sky, her mind racing, trying to process what she was seeing.

The world around her seemed to fall away. The noise in her mind quieted. There, in that moment, it felt undeniable. There was no mistaking it. A sign had been given. It was up to her to accept it.

"Lord, it's You. You're real. It's really true."

Tears welled in her eyes as it hit her, all at once. The years of doubt, the endless questions—all of it was swept away in that single, quiet moment. She collapsed to her knees, her legs giving out beneath her. She couldn't help it. The tears came without warning, streaming down her face, but this time, they weren't tears of confusion or fear. They were tears of awe. Of relief.

This—this was real. God had answered her. He had shown her. Not in some grand, theatrical way—but in the simple, undeniable beauty of that cross in the sky. It was enough. More than enough. People she would tell about it might not believe her, surely a sign like that can't be real, it's too on the nose, too obvious. But the sign was for her alone, in that moment alone, and it was Alex's interpretation that mattered.

Alex closed her eyes, her hands trembling as they gripped the earth beneath her. She whispered through the tears, a soft, broken prayer, her voice cracking as she spoke the words that had been building in her heart for so long.

“I believe. I believe in You.”

And as she knelt there, the world around her faded into quiet, and the truth settled deep inside her. It wasn't just something she wanted to be true. It was true. She was no longer searching, no longer questioning. She had found her north star. And this time, she was finally ready to follow. To follow. To deny herself and her petty nonsense and pick up her cross.

Chapter 9

The chill of autumn settled into the air as Alex stood at the park's edge, watching the leaves flutter to the ground. Each one seemed to carry a whisper of wisdom, urging her to reflect on her journey. It was a time of transition, not just in nature but within her spirit. With Grace beside her, she felt a sense of safety that had eluded her for so long. The two of them were fast friends now, and Alex had told her about what she saw in the clouds while running. They went for walks in the evening after work fairly regularly.

As they walked along the winding paths, Alex opened up on her struggles with making a full transition from her addiction to her doubts and her story to her new focus and faith. "I feel like I'm constantly battling this darkness," she confessed, her voice barely rising above the rustling leaves. "No matter how hard I try to move forward, something always pulls me back. I believe in the good, and I believe in purpose, but the dark is still there."

Grace paused, turning to face her. "You've been through so much, Alex. It's okay to struggle. It will take time to completely resolve everything." Alex nodded, her heart heavy yet hopeful. "But I don't want to just survive. I want to thrive," she said, her voice stronger. "I want to find a way to embrace who I really am, to uncover that part of myself that feels buried beneath all this chaos."

As they continued to stroll through the park, Alex felt the autumn sun warming her skin. It was a reminder that light could break through even the darkest of days. As they meandered, Grace's previous talk on idolatry struck her: What if the distractions I've been chasing—work, status, validation— have kept me from seeing the truth that's been there all along? What if the Holy Spirit has been present in every struggle, every moment of despair? What if those struggles were necessary to get to this exact point?

"Grace, do you ever feel like we get so caught up in the noise of our lives that we forget all about what really matters, or are you past that point now?" Alex asked, the words tumbling out.

"Absolutely," Grace replied, her gaze steady. "We live in a world filled with distractions—social media, career pressures, societal expectations. It's easy to lose sight of our true selves, of our connections to something greater."

A silence hung between them, filled with unspoken understanding. Alex's mind raced with the implications of what Grace had said. "Maybe that's why I've been so lost. I've let the chaos drown out the whispers from my heart. I've neglected the moments where I felt guided."

"Exactly. It's about tuning in, recognizing that there's a deeper purpose at play," Grace replied, her eyes sparkling with insight. "Think back to those moments when you felt overwhelmed—like in school, hiding in the bathroom. You weren't alone then, were you?"

The memory flooded back, vivid and raw. Alex remembered the warmth she felt during those dark moments, as if something beyond herself was holding her close, assuring her that she could endure. "I felt it," she whispered, tears prickling at her eyes. "It's like I had a guardian, even when I was at my lowest."

"Yes! That was the Holy Spirit guiding you, reminding you that you're never truly alone," Grace encouraged. "He's always been there, even when you didn't realize it. It's been whispering through the chaos, waiting for you to acknowledge Him."

As they sat on a bench overlooking a small pond, Alex closed her eyes, allowing herself to soak in the truth of Grace's words.

"Alex," Grace's voice brought her back. "It's okay to take a step back. You don't have to prove anything to anyone. What matters is how you feel inside. You're on a journey of rediscovery."

"I want to learn to listen—to silence the noise and be present," Alex said, her resolve firming. "But where do I start?"

"Begin with stillness," Grace suggested. "Create moments of solitude where you can reflect. Whether it's journaling, meditating, or even running—find what allows you to empty yourself of the broken record thought patterns and allows you to talk to Him in earnest. Keep reading the Word and ask the Holy Spirit to grant you discernment, you will be surprised how often what you read seems entirely relevant to you."

That evening, as Alex settled back into her apartment, she took out her journal, feeling a sense of purpose ignite within her. "Today was a great," she wrote. "I realized that the Holy Spirit has been with me all along, through every struggle and every moment of despair. I've let modern distractions cloud my vision, but it's time to reclaim that connection as a part of daily life."

As she penned her thoughts, a flood of memories came roaring towards her—each moment of despair intertwined with the invisible hand that had guided her. The bullying, the moments of doubt, the failures at work—each had been part of a larger tapestry, one woven with threads of resilience, strength, and unwavering love.

The next few days were filled with quiet contemplation. Alex embraced the practise of stillness, carving out time each morning for reflection. She would sit in her favourite corner of the apartment, a warm cup of tea in hand, allowing her thoughts to drift. She began to notice the small moments that had previously gone unnoticed—the way the sunlight filtered through her window, the laughter of children playing outside, the stillness that enveloped her in those quiet moments.

And with each passing day, the clarity grew stronger. She felt the Holy Spirit's presence, guiding her through her thoughts, reminding her that her struggles were not in vain. They were stepping stones, teaching her invaluable lessons about grace, acceptance, and love.

One evening, after a particularly long day at work, Alex felt the familiar urge to retreat into darkness and a bottle of wine. The pressure of deadlines and expectations loomed large, and her mind regressed to dark and negative thoughts. But this time, she paused. She closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and centred herself.

What would I say to myself if I were a friend? she pondered. I would remind myself of my worth, of the light within me that cannot be extinguished. Of my incredible fortune to be chosen to be here by Him and to have the chance to know Him.

Opening her eyes, she grabbed her journal and wrote: "In this moment, I choose to embrace my imperfections. I choose to

honour the struggles that have shaped me, to celebrate the lessons learned.”

The words flowed freely, a cathartic release of everything she had been holding inside. She wrote about the moments of despair, the bullying she faced at work, and the haunting echoes of inadequacy. But woven into every word was a sense of gratitude—gratitude for the journey, for the people who had supported her, and for the divine guidance that had been her constant companion.

As she closed her journal, she felt lighter. The darkness that had threatened to engulf her now felt more like a shadow— present but no longer overwhelming.

Days turned into weeks, and Alex continued to cultivate her connection to the Holy Spirit. She started volunteering at support groups for depression and anxiety at a local community centre, finding fulfilment in serving others. Alex realised she hadn't thought much about others until now, only what they thought of her. The golden cow. Each interaction, each smile, reminded her of the light she carried within her and the light she could share with the world.

Through her service, she met others who were struggling, their stories varied. She found herself sharing her journey, the battles she had fought, and the strength she had discovered. And in doing so, she realized that every challenge had been a gift—a way to connect with others and to inspire them to find their own light.

One day, while volunteering, she met a woman named Sarah. Sarah seemed perfect, glossy black hair, a neat business blouse and skirt, and an expensive looking beige overcoat. She was a model “I have it together” modern woman. On closer inspection, something was missing. Her eyes told the story. Sarah was struggling.

“Hey, I’m Alex. I haven’t seen you before.” Alex greeted Sarah with a warm smile.

“Oh...hey,” Sarah replied, struggling to meet her gaze. “Yea. I don’t really know why I’m here. Things have kind of... been falling apart lately.

"How do you mean?" Alex asked, hoping to gently get Sarah to open up.

"I got fired today for poor performance. I just haven't been myself for months now, after the divorce..." Sarah began to cry, sitting down on the sofa at the edge of the rented hall.

"Oh wow. I'm so sorry. I can't imagine how you're feeling," Alex said, unsure what else to say. What can you say to that?

"Thanks," Sarah whimpered. "It's like when things go wrong, they just keep going wrong. The harder things get, the worse you feel, and the harder everything seems, it's like all you can focus on is your failings."

Alex knew exactly what she meant.

"I get that," Alex replied. "I haven't gone through a divorce, but I have felt like that. Honestly it took much less to break me. I have been beating myself up for every little thing for most of my life, and all it took was a few awkward moments at school to permanently scar me. You must be really strong to be able to last months in work with that going on! I passed out in school once, and it's been haunting me every since."

Alex began to laugh out loud, as inappropriate as it seemed. Sarah started to laugh too. Alex's openness was very disarming.

"Thanks, Alex. I'm glad I came now. I had no idea what to expect."

"To tell you the truth, I was in a very bad place, I figured out a few things on my own, and I have a lot more to figure out for sure. I had a very good friend who could see I was struggling, and she reached out. She has gone through some terrible things herself, and she shared what helped her so much." Alex had carried the Gospels with her to the support group in case it was ever needed. "Look I'm not trying to push anything on you or take advantage of how you're feeling to push an agenda, but my friend gave me this and said I should read it and see if it helped. It didn't just help. It's changed my life. Please take it. If you throw it in the bin, fair enough, but I have to offer the best help that I believe I can."

"Thanks, Alex," Sarah said, as she reached over and took it. "I'll

head home and have a look tonight, I really appreciate you talking to me. Hopefully see you again.”

With that Sarah headed out.

As Alex left the shelter that day, the sun setting behind her, she felt an overwhelming sense of gratitude. Each struggle had led her to this moment—a moment of connection, of understanding, of recognizing that the Holy Spirit had been there all along, guiding her back to herself. There was a purpose to it all. She understood that the noise of the modern world would always be there—the distractions, the pressures, the expectations. But she had the power to choose how she responded to it. She could tune in to the whispers of her heart, the guidance of the Holy Spirit, and the love that surrounded her.

As Alex closed her journal that night, a sense of peace washed over her. She had begun to find her way home—to herself, to her purpose, to the divine presence that had been with her all along.

And with that realization, she took a deep breath, feeling the weight of the world lift, and embraced the journey ahead with open arms.

Chapter 10

The weekend came, and Alex wanted to get out into the frosty city for a walk. The cool air of early winter brushed against Alex's cheeks as she walked through the park, the world around her transforming into a winter wonderland. Snowflakes fell like whispers from the sky, blanketing the ground in white, softening the harsh edges of the city.

It had been weeks since her acceptance of God, and while the darkness still lingered at the corners of her mind, the light within her now burned brighter. She had started to view her past not as a collection of mistakes but as stepping stones toward a more profound understanding of herself and life. Yet, as she wandered memories of her struggles played out like a haunting film reel, desperate to regain their position on the throne of her psyche. If only I had known then what I know now, she thought, a twinge of shame stirring in her chest. She stopped on a park bench, gazing at the falling snow, and began to speak softly to herself, the stillness allowing her thoughts to flow freely. Her mind wandered back to her time spent on self-help, and she reflected on the lessons learned and the ultimate shortcomings of the advice she had read. Alex listened to motivational talks—including well known military veterans talking about how to achieve your goals and push yourself to new levels. However, the effects were typically short lived.

It helped her start running, but the effects wore off. It wasn't real change. It wasn't inspiring. It wasn't purpose. It wasn't truth. It was serving any greater good or in service of anything other than herself. She had no deep connection to the change she sought to make.

Why run? What was the result? Who was helped? Was she really just reinforcing her neurosis? Was this a deep-rooted purpose driven choice?

She concluded that "grind culture" was something easy to sell but not overly useful beyond getting out of your chair. It was surface level as a motivator and not a solution. This content existed to sell itself. It was entertaining and provided stimulus

while listening to it, and so it sells and gets plenty of attention.

Alex had also spent a few weeks trying mindfulness. The appeal of Eastern philosophy was strong, the appeal of peace and escape from the suffering inflicted by her own mind. Alex learned that her concept of herself was largely illusory, that her idea of herself and her relative position to everyone else was based upon premises she had accepted along the journey of her life, the people she had met and her upbringing. Alex found some comfort in the learning that her thoughts were often simply a looping record, not something consciously chosen or focussed upon. This realisation helped Alex learn meditation and the brief blissful pausing of her thoughts. This seemed like the ultimate answer. But one thing was missing: purpose. Simply not thinking is not a *raison d'être*, it is not a sufficient focus for life, nor does it answer the key questions we all have in life. It is a somewhat effective Band-Aid on the wound of overthinking and nothing further than that.

The final piece of the puzzle clicked for Alex. She was never satisfied because she was obsessed with herself. Every attempt to improve herself or how she felt only served to entrench her more deeply with her own wants and what she thought she needed. The real answer was in trusting something greater. She had heard it said that surrendering her will would lead to the peace of God which is beyond all understanding, and she finally understood what that meant.

"Remember that day in school," she murmured. "When I passed out in Biology? I felt so small, so powerless. I wish I could go back and tell that girl that her worth isn't defined by others' opinions. I'd tell her to stand tall, to find strength in her uniqueness, to embrace her body, her spirit."

The air felt thick with emotion as she continued her monologue. "I've been terrified of rejection, so I hid away, thinking that was the safest option. But now, I understand that vulnerability can be a strength. I could have reached out, sought comfort in my friends, shared my pain instead of burying it. 'You don't have to carry this alone,' I'd tell her. 'You have a community around you, even if it doesn't always feel that way.'"

The memories brought tears to her eyes, yet they were not

solely of sadness. There was a sense of liberation in acknowledging her past choices. "And at work...", she sighed, her breath forming small clouds in the cold air. "I wish I had seen Michael for what he truly was—a mirror reflecting my own insecurities. Instead of letting his words cut me, I could have recognized them as a cry for help, a reminder that I needed to fortify against the changeable opinions of others by focussing on something more."

She closed her eyes, letting the cold air fill her lungs. "I could have chosen kindness, not just to him but to myself. I have my baggage and trauma and past experiences, and he does too. Really in those moments, it is his trauma interacting with mine, rather than an authentic interaction.

The realization slowly and gently washed over her like the gentle snowfall, a blanket of understanding wrapping around her snugly. "If I had taken a step back then, maybe I would have seen that everyone else was struggling too." Alex realised this was the key to forgiveness. If everyone is plagued by their past and their subconscious, then they will keep acting that out because they need love in some area or in some form that they aren't getting. "In attacking me, Michael is really seeking approval from those surrounding him. It gives him a temporary comfort. He is seeking love, and yes, it is selfish, but he isn't aware of what he is doing, and that's all it is."

She remembered Jesus's words when on the cross: "Forgive them, for they know not what they do." Alex truly understood the words now. She also realised she could forgive Michael. "I have been selfish too. I have sought love at the expense of others due to my sense of lack. I come at it differently, I attack myself and he attacks others, but it is fundamentally the same issue. My self-attack impacts others also because they aren't receiving support from me as I am so self-absorbed. I forgive you, Michael."

As the snow continued to fall, Alex felt a wave of gratitude flood her being. "I am grateful for those moments, even the painful ones. They taught me resilience, humility, and compassion. They have shaped the person I am becoming and my ability to contribute towards the suffering of others who haven't been lucky enough to learn the same lessons yet."

Turning on her heels at the end of the park to make the return journey, she looked up into the snow falling, enjoying the cold. She looked around the building tops that surrounded the park, before her eyes landed on a section of clouds. There was a bird-shaped clearing in the clouds. In the centre of the clearing, there was what looked like a small island with a single tree on it. Alex felt the words simplify your life come to mind. Alex knew with absolute certainty that this was another sign. She was being given guidance. The bird represented freedom. Simplicity was at the heart of freedom. She needed to focus on the core elements of her life. Faith, accepting herself, and uplifting others. The rest was noise.

That evening, she returned home and opened her journal. The pages were filled with reflections, realizations, and moments of vulnerability. She began writing again, her thoughts pouring out as if they had been waiting for the right moment to be set free.

"Today, I embraced my past and the lessons it taught me. I will not shy away from my experiences but rather allow them to fuel my growth. I want to be the kind of person who lifts others, who inspires them to find their strength. I will hold space for their pain and remind them that they are never alone. I have purpose now, I have guidance in Him, and I know how I want to live my life. I know it is important to accept every part of myself. All of my flaws and needs have been born out of a painful situation or where I didn't get what I thought I needed at the time. I know now that part of me isn't something to shun and try and ignore. It is part of my psyche, and I accept it. I know sometimes I will have to satisfy the irrational needs that I have. I might need to pray to the Lord for something seemingly trivial, but I know He knows I need to. He invites us to. He said, 'Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest.' I accept who I am, all of who I am, and I orientate all of it towards Him.

"I know I will have petty needs and sometimes I will satisfy those. I will have an occasional glass of wine if I want to. I will share problems with friends if I feel the need. I respect my weaknesses and want to work with them, not do battle with myself."

As she penned her thoughts, the shadows were very much on the periphery of her awareness, and no closer than that. She felt

the presence of the Holy Spirit. He whispered to her that every misstep had been a chance to learn, a way to prepare her for the road ahead.

With each passing day, Alex began to weave these realizations into her interactions. At work, she approached her colleagues with newfound empathy. When Michael made snide comments, she met them with kindness rather than anger, often replying with a genuine smile. "I hope you're doing well today," she would say, her voice steady, turning the tide of negativity into an opportunity for compassion.

One afternoon, she found herself in a meeting where tensions ran high. The pressure of deadlines had everyone on edge, and she felt the familiar anxiety creeping back. But instead of succumbing to the darkness, she spoke up, her voice steady and clear. "I understand we're all under a lot of stress. But we have worked hard, and we are all prepared. We're in this together and we have put ourselves in a good position, we need to map out the closing tasks and it will be a job well done."

Her proclamation surprised her colleagues, and for a moment, the room fell silent. Then, one by one, they nodded, taking a collective breath. The atmosphere shifted, and Alex felt a swell of pride. This is what I want to do—bring people together, remind them of their worth, and lift the heaviness from their hearts.

Alex was on a whole new path. She was in partnership with herself and orientated towards the Lord. Feeling like a leader in Brightfield for the first time since she had joined, she made her way for the exit at the end of the day. Michael caught up to her and called out. "Hey, Alex, wait up. Look, I just wanted to say sorry. I've been rude to you so many times, and you never did anything to deserve it. I'm sorry."

"No problem, Michael, I forgive you. It's a stressful environment. I haven't exactly helped myself either. We're good."

"Yea, I guess I just wanted to be on top in here. You seem like you've really stepped up lately."

"I'm trying," Alex grinned. "This place isn't easy."

"So, uh...now that we're cool...Do you fancy going for a drink after work?"

Alex looked at him with one eyebrow raised, utterly bemused and unsure whether to laugh or cry.

"Sure."

MATTHEW 11:28

"Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest."

About the Author

I write to try and help people through difficult issues by offering relatable stories and character journeys where the character muddles their way to answers.

I'm the author of *James and His Chocolate Bar*, a self-help story for children about addiction, which has been downloaded over one thousand times. My writing is rooted in personal experience and a desire to bring light to the struggles we often keep hidden. I believe in the power of honest storytelling to gently open conversations about topics we find difficult to confront. I am honoured to have this book available as a learning resource in Hope4Life's learning resource collection, which is issued to schools when the charity visits their classes to discuss some of the more difficult topics with children—bullying, mental health and much more. They do amazing work.

The lessons I have learned and wish to impart are based on personal experience, years of self-development work, years of working with individuals to help them perform and meet goals in the fitness industry, years of working in busy and stressful corporate environments, as well as volunteer work for mental health charities speaking to people dealing with unimaginable difficulties.

For *From Anxiety to Faith*, finding God has both changed and saved my life. I am compelled to pass the message on, especially to those who are struggling with anxiety and for whom nothing seems to really help.

A Note to the Reader

Thank you for reading Alex's story.

If any part of it felt familiar—the voice that never seems satisfied, the exhaustion of trying to be enough—I hope you were able to take something from how she found her way through it.

This book is free to share. If it helped you, please pass it on to anyone you think might need it: a friend, a colleague, a small group, anyone quietly carrying something similar. Reach matters more to me than anything else here.

If you'd like to help in another way, a short review wherever you found this book—Amazon, Apple Books, Goodreads, anywhere—makes a real difference. It's often the only thing that decides whether the next person gives a book like this a chance.

And if you'd like to know when something new is out, drop me a line at anxietytofaith@outlook.com and I'll keep you posted.

With thanks, Alex